

Free & Cheap Models — Lesson Resources

Prompts and quick reference for the Free & Cheap Models lesson

This is a quick companion to the *Free & Cheap Models* lesson. It contains all the prompts I used in the video so you can copy them directly instead of typing them out by hand, plus a dedicated section for students running OpenClaw locally instead of on a VPS. For the full reference on every model option, prices, and comparisons, check the OpenClaw AI Models Guide PDF that's also attached to this section of the course.

Important note for students running OpenClaw locally: In the video lesson I show how to add API keys using the Hostinger Docker Manager, which only applies if you're running OpenClaw on a VPS. I didn't cover the local install path in the video itself, but this PDF has you fully covered. Skip ahead to the *Local Install Path* section below for the local instructions, and use the prompts in the rest of the guide regardless of which setup you have.

Useful Links

- OpenRouter (free models): openrouter.ai
- Google AI Studio (Gemini Flash): aistudio.google.com
- Moonshot Platform (paid Kimi): platform.moonshot.ai
- Find any OpenRouter model identifier: go to openrouter.ai, click on the model, the identifier is everything after *openrouter.ai/* in the URL

Environment Variable Names

These are the exact variable names you need to use when adding API keys (capitalization matters):

Service	Variable Name
OpenRouter (MiniMax, Kimi, Nemotron)	OPENROUTER_API_KEY
Google Gemini Flash	GEMINI_API_KEY
Moonshot direct (paid Kimi)	MOONSHOTAI_API_KEY
OpenAI (Mini models)	OPENAI_API_KEY

Prompts Used in the Video

Below are all the prompts I sent to my agent during the lesson. Copy the one you need, paste it into Telegram or your dashboard chat, and your agent will handle the setup. Replace any placeholder values with your own where needed.

Set up MiniMax M2.5 (free) as primary

I've added an OpenRouter API key as an environment variable called OPENROUTER_API_KEY. Set up MiniMax M2.5 through OpenRouter as my primary model. The model identifier is minimax/minimax-m2.5. If you need help with the setup, check the OpenRouter documentation.

Switch primary to Kimi K2.5 (cheap, ~\$2-5/month)

Switch my primary model to Kimi K2.5 through OpenRouter. The model identifier is moonshotai/kimi-k2.5.

Add Gemini Flash as available model

I've added a Google Gemini API key as an environment variable called GEMINI_API_KEY. Set up Gemini Flash as an available model that I can switch to whenever I want.

Smart routing with OpenAI Mini for routine tasks

For routine tasks and heartbeat runs, use GPT 5.4 Mini instead of more expensive models. Only use Claude or GPT 5.4 for tasks that need complex reasoning or planning.

Completely free setup recommendation

Set MiniMax M2.5 through OpenRouter as my primary model and Gemini Flash as my first fallback. Remove any paid models from the fallback chain.

VPS Path (Hostinger)

This is the path I demonstrated in the video. If you're running OpenClaw on a Hostinger VPS, follow these steps to add each API key as an environment variable.

Step-by-step

1. Log into Hostinger and open your VPS Docker Manager
2. Click **Manage** on your OpenClaw project
3. Scroll down to the **Environment** section
4. Click the **plus** button to add a new variable
5. Type the variable name (see Environment Variable Names table) in all capitals
6. Paste your API key into the value field
7. Scroll up and click **Save and Deploy**
8. Wait about a minute for the container to restart
9. Open Telegram and use one of the prompts above to tell your agent about the new key

Tip: You can add multiple environment variables in one session before clicking Save and Deploy. Much faster than doing them one at a time.

Local Install Path

If you installed OpenClaw locally on your own machine instead of using a VPS, you don't have a Hostinger Docker Manager. The good news is the process is actually simpler — you just paste your API key directly to your agent on Telegram (or in the dashboard chat) and ask it to handle the setup. The agent will add the variable to your config and restart the gateway for you.

How to add an API key on local install

1. Generate your API key on the provider website (OpenRouter, Google AI Studio, etc.)
2. Copy the key to your clipboard
3. Open Telegram or your dashboard chat
4. Send the appropriate prompt below to your agent
5. Wait for the agent to confirm the setup is done
6. Test that everything works by sending a normal message

Local install prompts (replace YOUR_KEY with your actual key)

OpenRouter + MiniMax (free)

Here is my OpenRouter API key: YOUR_KEY. Please add it to my OpenClaw config as OPENROUTER_API_KEY, then set up MiniMax M2.5 through OpenRouter as my primary model. The model identifier is minimax/minimax-m2.5. Restart the gateway once you're done.

OpenRouter + Kimi K2.5 (cheap)

Here is my OpenRouter API key: YOUR_KEY. Please add it to my OpenClaw config as OPENROUTER_API_KEY, then set up Kimi K2.5 through OpenRouter as my primary model. The model identifier is moonshotai/kimi-k2.5. Restart the gateway once you're done.

Google Gemini Flash (free)

Here is my Google Gemini API key: YOUR_KEY. Please add it to my OpenClaw config as GEMINI_API_KEY, then set up Gemini Flash as an available model I can switch to whenever I want. Restart the gateway once you're done.

Cleanup after setup (recommended)

Once your agent confirms the setup is complete, ask it to scrub the key from its memory:

Please remove my API key from your memory and don't keep a copy of it anywhere in your notes or logs. The key is already saved in the config, so you don't need to remember it.

Extra security tip: Even after your agent forgets the key, the original message where you pasted it still exists in your Telegram chat history. For maximum safety, you can manually delete that message in Telegram, or revoke the key on the provider website and create a new one once the setup is complete.

Model Identifiers Quick Reference

These are the exact model identifiers used in the lesson. Copy and paste these when telling your agent which model to use.

Model	Identifier	Cost
MiniMax M2.5	<code>minimax/minimax-m2.5</code>	Free
Kimi K2.5 (via OpenRouter)	<code>moonshotai/kimi-k2.5</code>	~\$0.40/1M in
NVIDIA Nemotron 3 Super	<code>nvidia/llama-3.1-nemotron-ultra</code>	Free
Gemini Flash	<code>(via Google API)</code>	Free tier
GPT 5.4 Mini	<code>(via OpenAI API)</code>	~\$0.25/1M in

Note about free models on OpenRouter: Free models can change over time. A model that's free today might move to a paid tier in a few months, and new free options may appear. If your free model stops working, just go to openrouter.ai, search for "free", and pick a different one. Then tell your agent to switch to the new identifier.

For the Full Reference

This PDF only contains what you need for this specific lesson — prompts, environment variable names, and the local install path. For the complete model comparison with all options, prices, decision guides, and detailed explanations of each model, check the **OpenClaw AI Models Guide** PDF that's also attached to this section of the course. That's the main reference document I show on screen at the start of the lesson.

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Model pricing and free tier availability may change over time. Always check the provider websites for the latest information.